

MODERN LANGUAGES AND LITERATURES CAPSTONE

I. Description and Overall Objectives

The Modern Languages and Literatures Capstone for the Chinese, French, and German Programs consists of a semester-long research project completed under a professor's supervision, guidance, and mentoring. With departmental invitation, an Honors Capstone can take place over two semesters. The MLL Capstone involves two main components in the target language. With careful and intentional guidance, students produce a significant research project of 20+ pages and give an oral presentation that engages questions in the target language from an audience. The student as author must formulate a hypothesis, develop a consistent and purposeful argument, communicate to readers what research methods and tools were used, indicate research results, and underscore how results were interpreted to address the hypothesis.

The overall goal is to practice and refine effective interdisciplinary thinking as it relates to your areas of interest. Topics covered usually address issues that arise in your culture, film, and literature courses. Working closely with an MLL professor, you will **create, focus, and shape your topic**. You will **develop a research question, draft a plan and an outline for addressing that question, seek to answer the question in your analytical reading and research via primary and secondary source materials in the target language, write regular section drafts of at least 3-5 pages for weekly or bimonthly meetings, share and discuss your writing and research progress, add target-language bibliographic material to your one-to-two-page bibliography, make regular revisions in consultation with your professor, and prepare your oral defense**.

A student planning to complete the Capstone chooses a professor with whom to work. It can help to speak with the professor about this a semester or two beforehand. Each professor will have her or his own organizational and mentoring style and methods. For example, where one might provide a broad set of grading percentages, another might prioritize a two-part grade based on the 20+ page written project and the oral defense. Participation at Southwestern's "From Every Voice Symposium" may be encouraged. All professors will provide the information below and share their scholarly insights and advising wisdom.

You should feel free to consult at any time with the professor supervising the Capstone. You will find that the strong study habits developed at Southwestern serve you well in meeting interim and end-of-semester deadlines. In some cases, submitting certain materials by specific deadlines may be required. For example, you may be asked to have a prospectus ready by a certain date (including thesis, methodology, research proposal, literature review, and project significance), or to have a ten-page draft in MLA format ready by mid-semester (including various works cited).

II. The Capstone as Original Research

In MLL, the Capstone student's hypothesis and analyses map out a new critical horizon. This original work moves scholarship forward by challenging an audience to consider new perspectives and to think differently. The research and writing for the Capstone facilitates a level of skill and originality that may enable future publication of the student's work. Related outcomes in MLL include new perspectives on texts, transformative engagements with texts, and interdisciplinary projects for double majors. The originality of the research involves appropriately representing the integrative, interrelated insights brought to the interpretation of literature, culture, art, and/or film. In some cases, the original research may involve accessing archives and making accessible hitherto unknown materials. In other cases, it may involve collecting interview materials. Students learn to adopt the scholarly methods best suited to advancing interdisciplinary research. All MLL students completing a Capstone integrate aspects of previous Southwestern courses. They often integrate other sources of knowledge, such as study abroad experiences and civic engagement.

Originality of research in MLL involves progressing as a reader, writer, and critical thinker according to 2012 ACTFL Proficiency Guidelines (ACTFL = *American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages*). MLL meets national ACTFL Proficiency Guidelines by offering numerous "Writing Attentive" courses and by prioritizing throughout its course sequence a progressive strengthening of

writing and research skills. In second-year French and German at Southwestern, for example, students move from meeting practical writing needs at the Intermediate level to beginning their practice of connected discourse of paragraph length and structure that corresponds to the Advanced level, which includes demonstrating the ability to develop arguments and construct hypotheses, but perhaps not consistently across a variety of topics treated abstractly or generally. In third- and fourth-year French and German courses, students practice a variety of rhetorical structures that direct their writing to an audience at the Superior level. Research and writing tasks for any given third- or fourth-year course continue practice of Superior-level skills, for example the ability to explain complex matters; to present and support opinions by developing cogent arguments and hypotheses; and to consistently structure and connect paragraphs that treat a variety of social, academic, and professional topics with intellectual sophistication, moving beyond the concrete to the abstract. MLL Capstone research is designed to then move students to the Distinguished level. Though not necessarily attained as an undergraduate, this level includes carrying out formal writing tasks such as position papers and journal articles. Students who demonstrate Distinguished level proficiency can write analytically and with intellectual rigor on professional, academic, and societal issues. In addition, Distinguished-level writers are able to address world issues in a highly conceptualized fashion, using persuasive and hypothetical discourse as representational techniques while communicating subtleties and nuances of opinion.

III. Scholarly Skills

To formulate a research question; to refine and expand the research question; to argue persuasively, fluidly, and with complex analytical insight in the target language; to read, analyze, paraphrase, synthesize, cite, and critique complex texts in the target language; to incorporate multiple kinds of evidence purposefully in order to generate and support writing; to craft arguments that matter in academic contexts; to skillfully structure a paper's organization; to effectively compile bibliographic materials; to develop flexible strategies for revising, editing, and proofreading writing; to demonstrate an awareness of the strategies writers use in different contexts; to demonstrate satisfactory oral and written proficiency according to ACTFL criteria, including well developed presentation and argumentation skills; to field questions based on independent writing and research.

IV. General Skills

- Develop an initial question, paper structure, and outline
- Create a folder where you will regularly save files
- Back up your files regularly in separate locations (computer, flash drive, cloud, etc.)
- Find primary sources and textual evidence to support your hypotheses
- Locate secondary sources to support your hypotheses
- Identify your Interlibrary Loan needs early in the semester
- Consider sociohistorical context
- Consider the context of experts' ideas, methods, and assumptions
- Consider your reader, who often asks that you justify, explain, argue, and convince, clearly and elegantly, with strong attention to the overall organization and flow of ideas
- Craft a clear, focused, original research question
- Follow the question as it evolves through your thinking and research – adapt as necessary
- Stay focused on the methods that work best for you – stick to a plan to generate steady content
- Use a variety of primary and secondary sources
- Balance your use of different media as appropriate – articles, books, films, web material, etc.
- Gradually expand your list of research sources
- Read wisely – sometimes slowly and carefully, sometimes focused on an Introduction or Conclusion
- Follow the experts' trail – find books and articles mentioned in their notes or bibliographies

- Try to paraphrase and synthesize – explaining someone’s ideas and their relevance is a skill that complements locating and citing those ideas
- Take careful notes – cite each and every source used as soon as you use it
- Cite judiciously – not too much or too little, and always explaining citations’ relevance
- Build a Works Cited list systematically – start right away with a few and build momentum

V. Honor Code: “I have acted with honesty and integrity in producing this work and am unaware of anyone who has not.”

It is fine and normal for the Capstone to discuss your work with your professor, to ask for comments and suggestions, and to incorporate suggestions. For this assignment, the first part of the pledge regarding “honesty and integrity” refers to a) relying on strong sources for your written work, b) not using any material without citing your source(s), c) using as appropriate only an online or print dictionary to look up a term or phrase and not an internet translator or other translation software, and d) communicating respectfully and consistently with your professor. Please feel free to share any comments, questions or concerns before writing the Honor Code Pledge on your final draft of this assignment.